

French A1 — Week 5 Student Overview

Crescere | Beginner French | Week 5

Theme: Getting Around — Aller, Places, and Directions

What You Will Learn This Week

Week 5 introduces *aller* — to go — one of the most useful verbs in French. It is also the most irregular: it doesn't look anything like its infinitive. You will memorize it this week because you will use it constantly.

You will also learn to say where you are going, how you are getting there, and how to give and understand simple directions. These are real-world skills that apply immediately whether you are traveling, navigating a French-speaking city, or just talking about your week.

What You Will Be Able to Say by the End of Week 5

By the end of Session 10, you should be able to have a short real-world exchange like this:

Vous: Excusez-moi, je cherche la pharmacie. **Passant:** La pharmacie ? Elle est à côté du supermarché — vous allez tout droit, puis vous tournez à droite. **Vous:** C'est loin d'ici ? **Passant:** Non, c'est à cinq minutes à pied.

And talk about your week:

Le matin, je vais au bureau en métro. À midi, je vais souvent à la boulangerie — c'est juste en face de mon bureau. Le week-end, je vais au cinéma ou au parc. Samedi, je vais à Paris en train.

Aller — Learn It by Heart

Aller (to go) is irregular. There is no shortcut — you memorize these forms:

Subject	Aller
je	vais
tu	vas
il / elle	va
nous	allons
vous	allez
ils / elles	vont

Say them out loud: *vais, vas, va, allons, allez, vont*. Three times. Then cover the page.

The à + Place Rule

When you say where you are going, *à* changes depending on the gender of the place:

If the place is...	Use	Example
masculine (<i>le</i>)	au	<i>Je vais au café.</i>
feminine (<i>la</i>)	à la	<i>Je vais à la banque.</i>
starts with a vowel or silent h	à l'	<i>*Je vais **à l'*hôpital.</i>
plural (<i>les</i>)	aux	<i>Je vais aux restaurants.</i>

You cannot say *à le café* in French. It must always contract to *au*. This is not optional — it's just how the language works.

The easiest way to learn this: when you learn a new place, always learn its gender at the same time. *Le café* → I go *au* café. *La banque* → I go *à la* banque.

One Thing That Surprises Students This Week

Aller is used for the near future too. When you say *Je vais travailler demain*, you're saying "I'm going to work tomorrow." You are using *aller + infinitive* — a structure you will study more in Week 9. For now, just notice that *je vais* + a place or an infinitive both work.

What to Practice Between Sessions

After Session 9 — before Session 10:

1. **Say the *aller* conjugation from memory.** *Vais, vas, va, allons, allez, vont.* No looking.
2. **Write 5 sentences.** Where are you going this week, and how? *Je vais au cinéma samedi. Je vais au bureau en métro.*
3. **Say them out loud.** No notes on the third try.

After Session 10 — before Session 11:

1. **Practice the directions phrases.** *Tout droit, à droite, à gauche.* Say each with a clear hand gesture.
2. **Write a 4-line dialogue.** Someone asks where the pharmacy is; you give directions. Exchange written and spoken.
3. **Review your prepositions.** Can you say where 5 places in your neighborhood are, using *près de, à côté de, en face de*?

Vocabulary to Know Before Week 6

See the full list in your Week 5 Vocabulary Reference. The most important items for Session 11 are:

- All six forms of *aller* from memory
- *au / à la / à l'* with 6 core places
- *en voiture / en bus / à pied / à vélo* — the four most common transport modes
- *près de, loin de, à côté de, en face de* — the four core prepositions of place
- *tout droit, à droite, à gauche* — the three direction phrases

Crescere — French A1 Week 5 / Questions? Contact your instructor.